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On Masculinity
Organizing Men: Power, Discourse, and the Social Construction of Masculinity(s) in the Workplace

by Dennis K. Mumby

We are Reason's
evident efficiencies
its proper beneficiaries.
We make the histories happen, patterns
fall our way and
all the best eventualities
are games we play.
We are confident
of our entitlement
to rule you.
(From "Hard Rulers" by Richard
Johnson, in Mac an Ghaill, 1996,
p. 17)

The purpose of this essay is to draw attention to an organizational phenomenon that is both central to, and invisible in, organizing processes, that is, the role of men in the workplace and the concomitant social construction of organizational masculinity(s). Such a topic is ironic, given that men are, either implicitly or explicitly, the putative subject matter of the vast majority of organizational theory and research. Frequently, however, it is precisely the pervasiveness of a phenomenon that renders it invisible both to everyday actors and to the social scientists who study human behavior. The goal of this paper, then, is to subject that invisibility, or centrality, to close critical scrutiny and, to borrow Jeff Hearn's (1996) phrase, "deconstruct the dominant" and "make the one(s) the other(s)" (p. 611). Put simply, the principal goal of this paper is to undercut the tendency to conflate "women" and "gender" and to demonstrate the importance of showing that men have gender, too.

Toward this end, I have several objectives in this paper. First, I want to position myself as a male social critic writing from a feminist perspective. In particular, I am interested in the politics of theory and the ways in which theory can aid in the development of a critical social consciousness and the concomitant alleviation of social inequities. From this perspective, the central issue in-

volves the question of what role someone from the "male-stream" can play in this process. Put another way, how does one politicize a voice that traditionally has been dominant (and thus viewed as "non-political" and "common sense")? The feminist rallying slogan of "the personal is political" was and is a cry from the margins, an appeal for women's consciousness-raising through the politicizing of what had previously been seen as irrelevant to politics and the public sphere of debate. Such a strategy is woman centered. Spoken from the masculine center, such a slogan perhaps rings hollow. My goal, therefore, is to suggest ways in which the feminist male social critic can position himself in ways that contribute to the critique of extant, gendered relations of power. In other words, how does one critique patriarchy from a masculine subject position?

One answer to this question is offered in the second section of the essay, where I introduce the reader to a small but growing body of literature in organization studies that examines the social construction of masculinities. In much of this work, hegemonic masculinity is analyzed as a socially constructed, institutionalized system of power that simultaneously privileges a certain definition of masculinity and marginalizes other competing forms. In the second part of

this essay I explore some of this work as a way to draw attention to the importance of not accepting male power as a given, monolithic structure, but of examining the tensions and contradictions that are inherent in hegemonic masculinity.

Finally, I provide a comparative analysis of two recent organizational ethnographies (Collinson, 1992; Kunda, 1992). The purpose of this analysis is twofold: to illustrate the multiple ways in which hegemonic forms of masculinity can be constructed and to show that masculinity can frequently take forms that are tension filled and contradictory, serving both hegemonic and resistant functions.

Critiquing Concentric Subjects: Doing Feminism From a Masculine Perspective

In her discussion of the emergence of a feminist consciousness, Teresa de Lauretis suggests that such consciousness is rooted in a paradox regarding the status of women:

the paradox of a being that is at once captive and absent in discourse, constantly spoken of but of itself inaudible or inexpressible, displayed as spectacle and still unrepresented or unrepresentable, invisible yet constituted as the object and the guarantee of vision; a being whose existence and specificity are simultaneously asserted and denied, negated and controlled. (de Lauretis, 1990, p. 115)

For de Lauretis, the goal of feminism is to engage that paradox—to explore the potentially fertile theoretical and political position of being simultaneously “inside its own social and discursive determinations and yet also outside and excessive to them” (1990, p. 116). Men engaged in feminist theory and research (particularly White, heterosexual men like myself) face a different kind of paradox, but a paradox nevertheless—one that derives from their position as the principal articulators of institutionalized systems of power and dominance. In such a context, Stephen Heath argues, “men’s relationship to feminism is an impossible one” (Heath, 1987, p. 1). In other words, however much men might consider themselves feminist and thus a part of the feminist cause, they are ultimately a part of the problem because of their complicity with patriarchal domination.

Just as de Lauretis argues that it is the paradoxical status of women that feminism must engage, however, I would suggest that it is precisely the “impossible” and paradoxical relationship to feminism (and women) that men need to take on in order to find ways to contribute to the critique of patriarchal systems of domination. As a way of participating in this engagement, below I perform some word play around de Lauretis’s (1990) concept of the “eccentric sub-

ject”—a term that she uses to describe a shift in historical consciousness that entails

a dis-placement and a self-dis-placement: leaving or giving up a place that is safe, that is “home”—physically, emotionally, linguistically, epistemologically—for another place that is unknown and risky, that is not only emotionally but conceptually other; a place of discourse from which speaking and thinking are at best tentative, uncertain, unguaranteed. (p. 138)

Eccentric subjects, then, are essential to feminist movement insofar as they represent an “excessive critical position” (p. 145) that refuses to affirm sameness and uniformity. In this sense, tension and contradiction lie at the heart of feminism because it provides continual possibilities for thinking otherwise and for exploring alternate realities and hence moving toward empowerment.

Masculinist subjectivities, on the other hand, experience empowerment through concentricity. That is, men—as “concentric subjects”—have a common center by virtue of the dominance of patriarchy in contemporary society. Kanter’s (1977) classic, *Men and Women of the Corporation*, for example, points to the notion of “homosocial reproduction” as a pervasive expression of this concentricity. Men reproduce themselves in ever-increasing circles. “Hegemonic masculinity” is both medium and outcome of this process.

That is, a certain dominant form of masculinity provides both an interpretive frame for acceptable organizational behavior, and is the product of that behavior. In more general terms, men (particularly White, heterosexual men) are concentric subjects in that their everyday being-in-the-world can be carried out in a largely unreflective fashion. By virtue of being White, male, and heterosexual, I am not confronted continuously by taken-for-granted, institutionalized practices that are threatening and oppressive to me. The world is pretty much made in my own image and so, for me, complacency is not something that would pose a threat to my way of life. As a masculine subject, I am concentric (i.e., share a common center) with the dominant values of modern institutions.

As a "concentric subject," however, I am also well placed to critique and undermine the ways in which dominant masculine subjectivities are produced and reproduced. Whereas de Lauretis's feminist subject has the status of "outsider within" ([Hill Collins, 1991](#)), as a male critic of patriarchy I have the status of "insider within," working to deconstruct a system of power of which I am a part. Stuart Hall refers to such a move as the "alienation of advantage." As he puts it, "the vocation of intellectuals is to alienate that advantage that they have had

out of the system, to take the whole system of knowledge itself and . . . attempt to put it at the service of some other project" (quoted in Hennessy, 1993, p. 4).

So, perhaps the role of the male feminist is to understand and critique concentric (i.e., common, unmarked) subjects—those that reproduce (albeit in a different form) and mirror the hegemonic, unmarked center of patriarchy. Most forms of masculinity are concentric in their maintenance of a structured system of power relations that subordinate those subjectivities—feminine, homosexual, lesbian, African American, and so forth—that threaten the stability of the center. In this context, one role of the male feminist is to interrupt and break the circle/cycle of homosocial reproduction that keeps patriarchy in place and to pursue an undermining of the notion of a singular, stable, totalizing subject.

These moves enable us to see the various ways in which hegemonic masculinity is socially constructed through various discursive and nondiscursive practices and simultaneously draw attention to the fact that "stable notions of self and identity are based on exclusion and secured by terror" (Pratt, quoted in de Lauretis, p. 136). In this sense, social constructions are neither arbitrary nor the product of consensus among social groups. Rather, they are rooted in power and

reflect the ability of the powerful to “fix” meaning in ways that privilege those forms of reality that serve the interests of the powerful. As Laclau and Mouffe (1985) have so ably shown, however, meanings are never fully fixed, or “sutured” (to use their term). There is always an excess of meaning, which escapes the purview of the dominant center. Apparently concentric subjects contain kinks, gaps, fissures, and ruptures of various kinds. It is here that resistance to hegemonic forms of power can occur.

If, indeed, our subjectivities are discursively constructed, then we can examine the ways in which masculinity as an ideological system is constructed, maintained, and reproduced through various formal and informal practices (Bird, 1996; Collinson, 1988, 1992; Hearn, 1992, 1994; Willis, 1977). From this perspective, writing as a man from a feminist perspective involves a commitment to making visible and deconstructing the dominant worldview of which one is a part. As Hearn (1996, p. 614) states, “Deconstructing the dominant (or the superordinate) involves making clearer the social construction of ‘men’, of ‘whiteness’, of ‘able-bodiedness’, and so on.”

In the next section, then, I turn to a relatively cursory discussion of the recently emergent critical literature on masculinity and organizations,

principally to provide the reader with a sense of how “the subject” of masculinity is an important area of study for those scholars interested in a radical critique of organizing processes. In particular, I argue that structures of organizational power and domination can be understood adequately only through a close, communication-based analysis of the ways in which organizational masculinities are constructed in a moment-to-moment, quotidian fashion. Only in this way can the interconnections among power, masculine identity, and discourse be fully understood.

Power, Critical Studies, and the Organization of Masculinity

In this section I want to take seriously West and her associates’ (West & Fenstermaker, 1995; West & Zimmerman, 1987) notions of “doing gender” and “doing difference,” both of which are premised on the idea that the differences that make a difference—principally, gender, race, and class—are situational accomplishments.¹ In this model, such identities involve not fixed characteristics or roles carried complete with each individual, but rather are mundane and routine accomplishments of everyday social interaction enacted in contexts of power. In this sense, masculinity(s) is not a stable feature of specific, individual men, but is constructed in an ongoing fashion

through various discourses, activities, and micropractices. Thus, I am interested in exploring how we can examine masculinity as a hegemonic construct that gets played out in a daily fashion in the context of institutionalized systems of power. Within this frame, masculinity is both process and product, medium and outcome of such power relations (Giddens, 1979). Moreover, I argue that masculinity is not a stable and unitary formation, but rather interacts with class in a variety of ways, depending on the social and political context. In this sense, even the same manifestations of masculinity can be simultaneously resistant and hegemonic (Collinson, 1988, 1992).

The current critical literature on organizational masculinities is premised on the centrality of power and the recognition that the primary definition of the relationship between men and women is, at least in an institutional sense, one of the domination by the former of the latter. Such work gains its impetus from feminist theory and research and its extensive and incisive critiques of patriarchal forms of domination. However, although feminist research focuses principally on the deleterious effects of patriarchy on women, as well as on women's various forms of resistance to patriarchal domination, the new literature on workplace masculinity is interested in rendering

problematic the very notion(s) of masculinity upon which patriarchy is founded (e.g., Cheng, 1996; Collinson & Hearn, 1996a, 1996b; Hearn, 1992, 1994, 1996; Mac an Ghaill, 1996).

Given its impetus by Connell's (1987) concept of "hegemonic masculinity," this work has systematically explored the processes through which certain definitions of masculinity have come to hold sway over competing definitions. This initial assumption has led to a call for a radical analysis of masculinity(s). Carrigan, Connell, and Lee (1985) argue that such a radical analysis is rooted in three steps: (1) an examination and understanding of masculinity as a political order and an exploration of the processes through which certain forms of masculinity become hegemonic; (2) efforts to make connections with feminist studies of the sexual division of labor, workplace gender politics, and the relations among race, class, and gender; and (3) an overcoming of the traditional bifurcation of structure and individual, society and social actor, and a focus instead on the ongoing "historical production of social categories, on power as the ability to control the production of people . . . and on large-scale structures as both the objects and effects of collective practice" (1985, pp. 552-553).

Furthermore, in their discus-

sion of homosexuality as a form of masculinity, Carrigan, Connell, and Lee state:

The history of homosexuality obliges us to think of masculinity not as a single object with its own history, but as being constantly constructed within the history of an evolving social structure, a structure of sexual power relations. It obliges us to see this construction as a social struggle going on in a complex ideological and political field, in which there is a continuing process of mobilization, marginalization, contestation, resistance, and subordination. (1985, p. 589)

Much of the contemporary critical literature on workplace masculinities attempts to explore precisely the issues with which Carrigan, Connell, and Lee are concerned here and to highlight the dynamics of institutional forms as they function as medium and outcome of masculinities. In short, the focus of this research is on hegemonic masculinity as a set of routine and contested practices—as “the political techniques of the patriarchal social order” (1985, p. 594).

In examining “men” at “work” (Collinson & Hearn, 1996a), much of the recent literature on workplace masculinities attempts to render problematic the rather simplistic notion that the hegemony of men over women and of certain masculinities over others is reducible to patriarchy as a dominant political, economic, and ideological system of

power. Such reductionist thinking is problematic for a number of reasons: (1) It takes the notion of patriarchy as a given, hence leaving it undertheorized; (2) by conceiving of patriarchy as a single, unified, monolithic structure, its complexities, tensions, and dynamic contradictions are frequently overlooked; and (3) following from this, the possibilities for resistance to patriarchy are downplayed in favor of its exploitative power. Recognizing these limitations of the concept of patriarchy, Collinson and Hearn (1996) call for “analyses that can begin to reflect and comprehend the multiple, shifting but tenacious nature [sic] of gendered power regimes as they characterize diverse workplaces” (p. 73). Below, I present two such analyses.

Deconstructing Hegemonic Masculinity in the Workplace: A Comparative Analysis of Two Studies

In this final section, and as a way of tying together the issues developed in this essay, I provide a comparative analysis of two recent and well-known organizational ethnographies, Gideon Kunda’s (1992) *Engineering Culture* and David Collinson’s (1992) *Managing the Shopfloor*. The latter is explicitly an examination of masculinity in the workplace; the former is not. However, I suggest that Kunda’s study is an interesting, if unwitting, analysis of the social construction of

white-collar masculinity. Juxtaposed against Collinson's study of working-class, shop-floor masculinity, the two studies provide rich insight into the ways in which different (and in some ways opposing) conceptions of masculinity are socially constructed through mundane organizing practices. In addition, the studies demonstrate how two opposing conceptions of masculinity both can construct themselves simultaneously as hegemonic and resistant. In this sense, a comparative analysis effectively draws attention to the fact that hegemonic masculinity can appear in multiple forms.

My analysis of Kunda's and Collinson's studies revolves in part around Connell's (1993) discussion of the shift from hegemonic masculinity rooted in confrontational style and interpersonal dominance, to one based in technocratic rationality. One might speculate that Kunda's and Collinson's studies illustrate respective examples of competing forms of masculinity, with Kunda's "high tech," white-collar engineers constructing a form of masculinity whose hegemony is in the ascendancy, while Collinson's blue-collar, production-based machinists enact a more traditional, class-based form of masculinity whose hegemony is perhaps in decline. A question central in my analysis is therefore the following: What is the relationship be-

tween the working-class masculinity of Collinson's machinists (with its foundations in a form of collectivism rooted in a sharp, gendered division of labor between workplace and household) and Kunda's organization members whose masculinity is rooted in a middle-class upward mobility with seemingly weaker gender divisions, but with the dominant conception of masculinity rooted in a virile mastering of the world through technology? I will show how Kunda's subjects locate their identities in a much more explicitly individualistic conception of self, whereas Collinson's subjects have, at least superficially, a stronger collective identity rooted in a working-class, oppositional consciousness. Kunda's subjects exhibit hegemonic masculinity in the form of domination through (technological) expertise, and Collinson's subjects enact their hegemony through an oppositional consciousness rooted in the "othering" of both women and white-collar managers.

In some ways, Collinson's study can be read as a sequel to Paul Willis's (1977) classic, *Learning to Labor: How Working Class Kids Get Working Class Jobs*. Willis shows how the high school "lads" in his study construct a resistant, masculine subculture that simultaneously rejects the middle-class values of the dominant school culture and prepares them for insertion

into the capitalist mode of production as exploited, expropriated labor. Collinson takes up the story in the workplace itself. Focusing on a group of machinists in the axle department of a truck factory, he reveals a complex and often contradictory system of meaning and identity formation that revolves around the intersection of issues of resistance, conformity, and control. Collinson shows how the machinists' discursive and nondiscursive practices (with a particular focus on humor and horseplay) function simultaneously to resist managerial attempts at co-optation of the workers, produce conformity to working-class norms of masculinity, and control workers who try to shirk their job responsibilities. Collinson interrogates the ways in which a working-class masculine identity is symbolically constructed through humor, "piss taking" (lampooning coworkers), and exaggerated claims about sexual prowess. Ultimately, he suggests, the particular form that this identity takes serves to undermine the possibilities for genuine resistance to capitalist exploitation of the machinists' labor. Collinson argues that such possibilities are undermined through discursive practices that construct a form of masculine identity—rooted in aggressive sexuality, a careful separation of private and work lives, and competitive individualism—that limit the possibili-

ties for solidarity and collective action.

In Kunda's study the primary focal point of analysis is the relationship between corporate culture and control of the worker. In contrast to Collinson's study, Kunda's subjects are career-oriented, upwardly mobile, white-collar workers who are heavily invested in their work identity. Much of his analysis is thus concerned with exploring the phenomenon of "normative control" whereby organization members experience work via a strong identification with the company's goals and values, and hence see what they do as intrinsically satisfying. In this sense, control is exercised by the company not through any form of coercion or direct surveillance, but rather by developing a claim on the employee's very sense of identity. As I indicated above, Kunda makes no gendered claims about the ways in which corporate culture, normative control, and employee identity intersect. However, I argue below that his analysis of high-tech corporate culture unwittingly provides some important insights into the social construction of a form of masculinity rooted in technological rationality. Certainly, the elements are present in his study for such an alternative reading: a White, male CEO who articulates a thinly veiled Protestant ethic as the principal driving force of the company; workers driven to

the point of burnout (a condition worn by employees as a macho badge of courage); and a workplace environment that devalues any form of work that is feminized (i.e., that plays an auxiliary, support role).

Below, I argue that a deconstructive, comparative analysis of these two studies reveals important "nodal points" of tension and contestation around which definitions of masculinity are constructed. These points are the following: (1) conceptions of knowledge and their relation to masculine identity, (2) conceptions of work and their relation to the development of self-identity, and (3) conceptions of possibilities for workplace resistance. I address each of these in turn.

Conceptions of Knowledge and Their Relation to Masculine Identity

Harry Braverman's (1974) *Labor and Monopoly Capital* provides a compelling analysis of the processes through which work under monopoly capitalism has become increasingly deskilled. Such deskilling is an outcome of a power struggle between capitalists and workers over who controls the labor process. Through managerial techniques such as scientific management, Braverman shows how this struggle for control is resolved in favor of management by separating conception and execution of work. Whereas once these pro-

cesses were united (in crafts and guilds, for example), under monopoly capitalism the conception of work processes becomes an exclusively managerial prerogative, with workers relegated to the role of simply executing already conceived work tasks. As Braverman points out, "in the setting of antagonistic social relations, of alienated labor, hand and brain become not just separated, but divided and hostile" (1974, p. 125).

It is within this context that one can examine the relationship between constructions of workplace masculinity and the process of knowledge production in both Kunda's and Collinson's studies. In the latter, the machinists' masculine identity is constructed in part out of an oppositional reading of the split between conception and execution of work. Although work conceived as simple execution of tasks is devalued in modern capitalism in favor of conceptual and strategic tasks, Collinson's machinists reverse this polarity as a way of simultaneously resisting managerial control and establishing workplace identity. In the latter view, workers are strongly invested in the privileging of manual labor over mental labor; indeed, for the machinists, doing an "honest day's work" and being a "working man" involve a valorization of physical, hands-on work. The machinists imbue such work with an integrity

that stands in stark contrast to their view of mental labor as suspect and feminized. As one worker states pithily, "Fellas on the shop floor are genuine. They're the salt of the earth, but they're all twats and nancy boys [homosexuals] in th'offices" (1992, p. 87). Thus, although the "objective" conditions of capitalism situate workers as controlled, commodified, and stratified labor, the machinists in this study elevate themselves above managers, white-collar workers, and women through discursive practices that associate their work with independence, freedom, honesty, and production. In contrast, nonproducers, a category that includes anyone who does purely mental work, are "fucking parasites" (p. 88). The kind of knowledge that these workers see themselves as possessing, then, is common-sense, grounded knowledge that allows them to successfully negotiate the world of work and the larger, outside world. Again, such knowledge exists in sharp contrast to the "abstract," theoretical knowledge of management. Placed in the context of workplace relations of power, a masculine, working-class, oppositional subjectivity is realized in part by reframing what counts as important forms of knowledge. Masculinity and what one knows are thus intimately connected.

In Kunda's study a quite different relationship between

knowledge and masculine identity is constructed. Whereas Collinson's machinists valorize manual labor and marginalize mental labor, Kunda's white-collar workers perform precisely the reverse articulation. For the latter, mental labor is a defining quality of their identities. As I indicated above, Kunda does not provide a gendered analysis of this organizational identity, but one does not have to read far beneath the surface of his analysis to see a masculine identity rooted in an aggressive approach to technical creativity. In this organization, the elites are those who generate cutting-edge knowledge, and who see themselves on a fast track to wealth and power. For example, Kunda (1992) describes a young engineer's office cubicle in the following way:

Over the desk is a page borrowed from an advertisement in the *New York Times Magazine*: simple, elegant white letters against a black background: "The race goes to the swift." . . . Next to it a clipping from the *New Yorker*: A manager holding a "smoking" club saying to an employee, on the ground, just clubbed: "That should take care of any more ideas from the right side of the brain." On the left, a card depicting a lonely fisherman on a small, icy island, fishing. All around are sharks: a graphic portrayal of the frequently heard metaphor for life at Tech. Next to it is a card with one word: "Winner[.]" (p. 196)

At Tech, then, a hegemonic masculinity is articulated through discursive and nondiscursive practices that privilege a technocratic style and mode of being. Masculine virility becomes equated with the ability to engage in highly technical and abstract forms of thought and knowledge production. Indeed, those in the company who do engage in nonmental work—security guards, custodians, and so on—are placed in a feminine support role and marginalized as “extraculturals” (i.e., functioning invisibly on the very margins of Tech culture).

Conceptions of Work and Their Relation to the Development of Self-Identity

In both studies, organization members’ construction of a masculine identity is closely tied to their relationship to the work process itself. For Collinson’s machinists, this identity is rooted in a clear bifurcation between the public world of work and the private world of home and family. In the work realm, the machinists construct their identities through both an oppositional relationship to managerial goals and values and via a conformity to working-class norms. In addition, there is a strong interdependence between conceptions of working-class masculinity and the machinists’ relationship to home and family. For the machinists, masculinity is tied to pride in work, but also to a refusal to

accept managerial definitions of what work is. Although management constantly attempts to foster a strong workplace culture—a “we need to pull together to succeed” orientation—the workers are continually seeking spaces of resistance that allow them to shape definitions of work. Thus, through manipulation of space, time, and production, workers are able to create their own informal culture of resistance that thwarts any efforts on management’s part to engage in the kind of normative control of which Kunda speaks.

For example, Collinson identifies the machinists’ toilet as an important “back region”:

Within this private enclave, the pervading atmosphere was one of “self-determination,” where the individual could be his “own man,” that is to say, be “free of” the coercive constraints of authority. . . . The widespread shopfloor view of the toilet as a collusive retreat was discernible on its walls that were covered in a “graffiti of resistance.” . . . Moreover, newspapers, cushions, cigarettes and pornographic magazines (mainly supplied by the self-named “Porn King”) were smuggled into the toilet underneath the bulky and baggy overalls worn by shopfloor workers. These overalls were part of the formally required dress of all shopfloor workers. Whilst this requirement to wear overalls represents another disciplinary practice that threatened the identity of working class men, it also enabled them to conceal artifacts that could be smuggled both into the toilet and out

of the factory. Here again, therefore, control was reconstituted as resistance. (p. 137)

This development of separate spheres within the workplace itself points again to the articulation of a working-class, masculine identity in which distinctions between work and leisure are carefully preserved. Such a conception makes sense within capitalist relations of production in which labor power is commodified, and hence bought and sold like any other product. Within this context, the machinists experience themselves as alienated forms of labor and hence refuse to participate in the production process beyond the limits of what they see as fair compensation for their work. As Collinson states, "the commodification of labour was drawn on by the men to rationalize and justify their own work avoidance. The general view was that, 'Management can't have the axles if they don't pay for them'" (p. 138).

Concomitantly, for Collinson's machinists, the construction of masculine identity requires the maintenance of a clear split between work and home. Particularly for the older workers, masculinity is defined in terms of a man's function as a provider for dependents; in this context, work is defined as a means to an end, rather than as an end in itself. Working-class masculinity is thus constructed as hege-

monic via a simultaneous resistance to middle-class, white-collar work values, and a presentation of self as head of a stable, tranquil, and natural family life. Such responsibility is a defining feature of manhood.

In Kunda's study, a quite different relationship between work and self-identity among organization members is apparent. Whereas identity among Collinson's workers is articulated through a clear bifurcation of public and private self, Kunda shows how the private self of the Tech worker becomes the principal focal point of the contested terrain of the workplace. For all intents and purposes, the distinction between private and public self is obliterated. Indeed, it could be argued (although Kunda does not make the argument in these gendered terms) that the construction of a masculinity grounded in a technocratic consciousness requires precisely this obscuring of the boundaries between public and private self.

The phenomenon of burnout exemplifies this collapsing of boundaries and demonstrates a commitment to the corporation. Indeed, Kunda suggests that, although officially burnout among employees is viewed as a problem, members often wear this condition on their sleeves. As Kunda states,

Displaying symptoms of burnout is one way of sending signals to one's

superiors. It is a sign that one is heavily invested in work, proof that one is allowing one's experience to be dominated by the requirements of the member role, evidence of commitment and self-sacrifice, and from this perspective, a call for some respect, a declaration that one has become a casualty. (1992, p. 203)

Although burnout is an extreme condition, it also makes visible the often tacit, hidden meanings associated with the development of self in the context of everyday work practices. On the one hand it suggests a loss of control, an inability to cope with the demands of work; on the other hand, it is an important expression of organizational machismo, articulated by men and women alike. Interestingly, it is a phenomenon that would be ridiculed by Collinson's machinists, both because it proves that white-collar workers are "nancy boys" who cannot stand up to the strain of hard work, and because it suggests a commitment to the organization that sacrifices integrity and independence.

In short, whereas Collinson's workers define their masculinity through separation of private and public spheres and the maintenance of a stable, patriarchal family environment, Kunda's high-tech engineers construct a form of masculine identity that is partly dependent on a devaluing of family, or at least on a recognition that family responsibilities have to be negotiated around work demands.

Conceptions of Possibilities for Workplace Resistance

Although it may seem strange to address the issue of resistance when my primary concern is the construction of hegemonic masculinity, it is important to situate hegemony as a dialectical phenomenon (Mumby, 1997). That is, no form of hegemony represents a "sutured totality" (Laclau & Mouffe, 1985), but rather is produced and reproduced through complex systems of domination and resistance. In the case of the two studies examined here, we can see two very different sets of processes through which hegemonic masculinity serves to simultaneously subject workers to structures of dominance, and enables resistance to that dominance.

In Collinson's study, resistance occurs partly through the processes, indicated above, in which the machinists reverse the valence of the separation of conception from execution of work and privilege their own form of work above others. In addition, separation of private from public spheres of life helps reinforce resistance to strategies of co-optation on the part of management. Ostensibly, then, resistance to management power is made possible through a clear and collective articulation of masculine, working-class identity, rooted in, to use Connell's (1993) terms, an interpersonal dominance style in which workers

struggle against management dominance and, in turn, assert their own dominance over wives and children. As Collinson points out, however, this ostensibly collective action on the part of the workers functions as a thin and fragile veneer that covers over a masculine individualism that severely limits possibilities for genuine collective resistance to capitalist expropriative practices. Though shopfloor humor, for example, may function simultaneously as a way to resist management initiatives and develop collective solidarity through initiation into work culture, such humor is at least partly a defense mechanism against feelings of inadequacy and crises of identity. Ultimately, then, masculine individualism—manifested in aggressive sexuality and the male breadwinner role—wins out over any form of collective, working-class resistance to the capitalist relations of production.

The privileging of individual over collective identity is well represented in the following extract from one of Collinson's interviews with a shopfloor worker:

D.C.: How would you describe yourself?

Bill: Oh . . . er . . . I wouldn't like to say. You'd better describe me. How do you mean? . . . Well I think I've brought me children up better than most in the area. They're well behaved and honest. . . . Yes it's outside

work, I suppose, . . . Where I advance myself, like in the way I've avoided having a council house [public housing] . . . being independent, not letting the council do it for you. . . . At heart, I've tried to be independent like. (p. 163)

Collinson points to the way in which Bill adopts a "critical narcissism" and self-aggrandisement that constructs his identity, not in relation to and solidarity with his fellow workers, but in contradistinction to them. Indeed, his self-definition, as well as his self-differentiation from others, excludes the work sphere and revolves around his private life of home and family. As Collinson indicates, through this differentiation of self from others, Bill effectively "subordinates his entire experience of work and workmates to financial security" (1992, p. 163).

Workplace resistance in Kunda's study takes on a very different and, in some ways, more subtle form. Because of the relatively unitary and strong organizational culture at Tech that blurs the boundaries between public and private spheres, workers engage in resistance through the subtle management of ambiguity within that culture. As Kunda shows, organization members are players in a complex and precarious social drama in which role embracement and role distancing exist in an uneasy tension. Whereas role embracement involves "submit-

ting to the company's definition of one's self" (1992, p. 173), role distancing, as the name suggests, involves both a cognitive and emotional separation of one's self from the beliefs and feelings demanded by the full member role. Thus, role distancing involves a measure of self-reflexivity and the ability to adopt a more calculating, strategic stance toward the management of self and others.

At Tech, then, the construction of a hegemonic, technocratic form of masculinity is contextualized within the ability of workers to engage in "discursive penetration" (Giddens, 1979) of the work culture, enabling them to limit the degree of "corporate colonization" (Deetz, 1992) or normative control to which they are subject. Hence, although some employees may completely embrace the member role (see the above description of a member's office), most members are continually engaged in the negotiation of an ambiguous balance between role embracement and distancing, all the time recognizing that they are taking part in a very serious game (Kunda, p. 192).

For example, Kunda presents the conversation below as typical of member role displays that incorporate "a self-conscious commentary that allows the protagonists to create a sense of ambiguity around the significance of the displays and

their implications for the self" (p. 189). The conversation takes place when two engineers run into each other in a restaurant:

"How are you?"

"Super! Super!"

"Haven't seen you since—when was it?"

"Last year at the management forum."

"Yeah. I'm over with Poseidon now."

"Super! Super!"

"It's really neat. They're going to wheel it into Sam's office pretty soon. He's gonna see the performance numbers and love it."

"Super! I hear it's tough getting anything through corporate these days." (p. 189)

After one of the engineers leaves, the other turns to Kunda and says, "He's vicious! He'll eat you alive! But I heard he's still a fifty-fifty. Not clear if he's a win or a lose" (p. 190).

This exchange nicely encapsulates the ways in which—beneath the public articulation of a single, uniform, universally embraced culture of commitment—members engage in an ongoing struggle to "construct and display an organizational self that will further their purposes" (Kunda, p. 192).

The principal difference, then, between forms of resistance in the two organizations revolves around the conception and location of self-identity. In the case of Collinson's engineers, resistance involves the

deployment of discursive practices that bifurcate the private self and the public self. While workers articulate a clear masculine identity in the workplace, the locus of much of this identity lies outside the work sphere with family and the objectification of women via sexual relations. In this sense, masculine self-identity serves to mitigate the marginalized status that these men occupy in relation to the capitalist mode of production.

For Kunda's workers, self-identity is very much tied up with work, and no such clear bifurcation of private and public selves occurs. Under the system of normative control, members engage in a game of role-embrace/distancing that entails an ongoing and continuous negotiation of the ambiguity inherent in the carefully engineered culture of the organization. In terms of the social construction of masculinity, workplace identities are constructed within the context of a struggle for control over organizational meanings and realities. Where the dominant culture demands role embrace around patriarchal norms of "immersion, incorporation, psychological maturity, and religion" (Kunda, p. 177), members carefully cultivate an ambiguous relationship to these norms. Thus, rather than rejecting corporate definitions of work and self, organization members develop a nuanced ability to simultaneously iden-

tify with the organizational culture and develop a healthy cynicism toward it.

Although I have focused on a contrastive reading of these two ethnographies, principally as a way of demonstrating the social construction of two different, but in their own ways hegemonic, forms of masculinity, there is an important sense in which the cultures of Tech and the truck factory are united. In both cases, we see ways in which an ostensibly shared culture of solidarity is undermined by the contradictory privileging of individual self-interest on the part of members of the respective cultures. Regardless of whether one is a white-collar or blue-collar worker, the reality of capitalism is that one's organizational identity is constructed in the context of labor commodification processes. However effectively such processes are ideologically obscured through various discursive practices, most organization members can at least partially penetrate such practices. In this sense, Kunda's and Collinson's studies represent two attempts to account for the ways in which labor commodification, and the forms of control that accompany it, are resisted by those who are commodified. In part, the relative failure of this resistance can be explained by employees' construction of hegemonic masculine identities that mitigate against the full con-

ception and execution of alternative organizing possibilities.

The primary concern of this comparative analysis, then, has been to show the ways in which the social construction of such masculinities is a routine, situational accomplishment of everyday organizing practices. By subjecting these construction processes to a close, communication-based analysis, we can better understand the ways in which gendered relations of power and domination are produced, reproduced, and transformed. As the work of Connell and others has shown, masculinity is not a stable, unitary, transhistorical phenomenon, but rather is articulated at the intersection of various social, political, economic, and historical moments. As (organizational) communication scholars, we are particularly well positioned to examine the mundane ways in which such processes of articulation are accomplished.

Conclusion

In this essay I have attempted to draw attention to a largely unexamined area in organizational communication studies, that is, the social construction of workplace masculinity. By and large, the tacit understanding of organizations as primarily masculine enclaves has led to this neglect. However, a focus on masculinity opens up a number of potential issues, particularly in critical studies

of organizational communication. First and foremost, masculinity itself becomes an object of study; the invisible center of organizational life is subject to the same level of examination as women in organizations have traditionally experienced. Second, through this focus on masculinity, we can begin to develop a more sophisticated and nuanced understanding of organizational masculinity than has heretofore been available. Whereas critical and feminist research has long identified patriarchy as a central, constitutive feature of structures of power and domination, much of this work has tended to view patriarchy as fairly monolithic and has paid little attention to the various, complex, and often contradictory forms that masculinity or patriarchy can take on. Indeed, my purpose in developing the comparative case analysis was to highlight the processes through which masculinity is constructed, drawing particular attention to the tensions and contradictions that a more monolithic conception of patriarchy might overlook. Finally, a critical focus on masculinity provides an important means by which male feminists can both contribute to a critique of male power and explore possibilities for more democratic organizing processes. As Jane Flax (1990) argues, both men and women are "prisoners of gender." It is important that we do not take for granted or

oversimplify the consequences
of this imprisonment for men.

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Notes

¹ In this essay I will not be directly concerned with the issue of race, but will focus more explicitly on the intersection of gender and class. Such an omission should not be read as a lack of concern for race issues, which are clearly central to the processes through which difference is constructed, but rather as a product of the space constraints of this forum.

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On Masculinity **Theorizing Masculinity With/In the Media**

by Robert Hanke

The relationship between masculinity and the media, which first came into focus in the 1970s and gained increased scholarly attention in the late 1980s, has continued to generate work that theorizes, interprets, and evaluates masculinity with/in the media. In the 5 years since Fejes (1992) completed his review of empirical mass communication research on masculinity, there has been a growing stream of books and articles within media studies that has shifted critical attention from what Fejes calls "masculinity as fact" to the facticity of masculinity. This work focuses on masculinity as

it is represented and defined in various media, genres, texts, or icons and the relationship between these sites and gender, the gender order, other cultural differences, identity and identification, the subject, experience, and reality in late capitalism. As has often been observed, the theoretico-political clusters of feminist and gay and lesbian studies have given particular impetus to the exploration of masculinity as a dominant cultural identity and invisible norm. At the same time, particular projects continue to be in dialogue with other theoretical work that has opened up mediated masculinities to new questions.

In media studies of the last decade, we have come to understand masculinity as "both a product and process of representation" (de Lauretis, 1987, p. 5). Within a constructionist approach to representation and meaning, some scholars have adopted a feminist poststructuralist orientation to "masculinity as signs," where masculinity is regarded as one of the subjectivities (or subject-positions) that make up our social identities (Saco, 1992). Within the growing body of work on gender representation and discourse in the media, particular attention has been paid to the representation of the male body, giving rise to debates over its cultural significance, political valences, and its materiality. Today, as Hall (1996) observes, the "body serves to